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John Goldthorpe

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

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Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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John Goldthorpe

Interviewed by Anne Murcott

7 March 2013, 8 November 2013

1: A Mining Family and Village, and Community Studies

I was actually born in a little village, partly-agricultural/partly coal-mining village, called Great Houghton, which is about half way between Barnsley and Doncaster.... My father came from a mining family. His father had been a skilled miner, who was then promoted to mine supervisor, or Deputy, and then to Overman, which is, as it were, the highest supervisory level before you get to managers who needed a professional mining qualification. My father's brothers went into mining, and some of his sisters married miners. My father, himself, worked all his life as a clerk at a colliery in the next village – spent 50 years in the same office as a wages clerk, and then a cost clerk. And my mother came from a rather different kind of family. She was one of four sisters, and two of her sisters married mineworkers, so we were, in part, a mining family. And the community that I grew up in this little village the majority of men in that village would work in the mine by the village, or in neighbouring mines.

The house we lived in was on the edge of a ridge overlooking the Dearne Valley, and there were two mines actually in the valley, less than a mile from the house. My father worked in the neighbouring village – the mine there. There were mines every few miles in that area.... There was a pathway, a bridle path, and then another footpath close to our house, that miners would walk from the village to the mine and back again. So you saw them coming back, black-faced, and so on – it's the kind of thing that I suppose a young child asked questions about. And then, of course, my father would talk about what was happening at the pit, and my uncles would always be talking about mines and so on. So you just grew up with the idea that that's what work meant - working down the mine or at least in the colliery in some role or other.

Visually from the windows in our house, you looked down this hill and saw in the valley below this enormous slag heap, and it had little tubs running along it, and then tipping at the top, so that's what I remember – watching these things. ... And from time to time, if the wind was in that direction – it usually was, that was the prevailing wind – it stank, and it would discolour metal and things. We used to put pennies out and watch them go green and yellow! ... My mother always had to be careful about that, not to put washing out when this plant was at full blast. ...

Very very low rate of women working. They were housewives. Very busy, because an enormous amount of washing and cleaning to do. No, women in that village worked until they married, typically. In fact, some even didn't work before they were married. They might be daughters helping their mothers if it was a big family and there were three or four miners in that family – father and then sons - working different shifts of course. Because it was all shift work, then you probably needed two or three people to do the housework and the cooking and the washing. Just the whole time, yes. Yeah.

Did you go to the local primary school?

Yes, local Church of England School. The village was - I suppose now you'd call it a "bimodal village". It had been an agricultural village, rather remote agricultural village, and then the mines started being developed in that area towards the end of the 19th century and then early 20th century, and so more housing was built for the miners. ...

In fact, my maternal grandfather – the one who figures in this book – he was the son of a Pennine hill farmer. There were five brothers in this hill farm, and they, as it were, went east. They were farmers themselves. My grandfather had some training as a builder, and they moved east to Great Houghton, first of all to build houses for the miners. To begin with, they built them for the mining company, some brick houses in the neighbouring village. Then they built stone houses in my village. Yes, stone, because that's what they were used to working with. I could show you some pictures. And these they then rented out – they made a business of this - and they also bought land there to farm. So they fitted into the older part of the village, which was largely stone-built.

Then in the inter-war years there was big housing development in the lower part of the village – Council housing. So the village was a bit divided between, as it were, the northern end, which was the old agricultural end, with still three or four farms, and stone-built houses, and the lower part, with the quite big brick Council house estates. So the school I went to was a Church of England school, built in stone, at the northern end of the village, and then there was the Council school, a red brick building at the southern end of the village.

So this was one reason when, for example, if you remember it, Dennis, Henriques and Slaughter's Ashton study [*Coal Is Our Life*, 1956], I thought, "Don't generalise from that to mining communities. My mining community and quite a few others I know are very very different". And so this built in a very early scepticism about generalising from community studies and a failure to recognise the degree of variability....

Yes. It did fascinate me. When I started studying history at university, I became quite interested in the history of the village. (pp. 5-6)

2: The Butty System

There were two main ways [of managing the workforce]. One was simply sub-contracting – the mine owner would simply sub-contract out the mine, or a part of the mine, to some sub-contractor - they were called "butties" - who would then be responsible for hiring labour, and controlling labour, and paying labour, and the mine owner would simply pay the butty for the amount of coal that he produced, which the owner would then sell. So this sub-contracting, or butty system had some advantages. It meant that the mine owner hadn't to worry about setting up some kind of management. But it did have disadvantages as well. Partly for the mine owner, because, really, he'd no control over the way in which the pit was worked, and it might not be worked in the way that would be most efficient in the long-term. And it also had major disadvantages so far as mine safety was concerned, and so from the beginning of the 19th century you got more and more state intervention in regulating the working conditions, safety conditions, in mines. So you did then get the development of a managerial and a supervisory system, and in some cases, in combination with what was called the "little butty system", where only a seam was let

out, or even just a particular work area, to a sub-contractor, and that little butty system was still operating in South Yorkshire when I was a child. It went out after Nationalisation.

You heard people talking about this. My father's father was a mine deputy, and these people were then really in this difficult position. They were paid by the mining company, but they often had to deal with these small butties – the leaders of the gangs – and negotiate very complicated pay rates, which were not only piece rates – I mean, so much money for so much coal – but then with allowances for if it was too hot, if it was too wet, if the rock was very difficult, if the seam was very narrow, and so on. So they were in a very difficult position. And then one of my mother's sisters' husbands had been a little butty – one of the gang leaders. By the time I knew him, he'd just become a day labourer in the mine because you couldn't keep up this piece rate working much beyond 40, you see – it's too strenuous. And so this was often coming up in conversation in the family and so on.

So that's why I wanted to work on this problem of how the management system evolved, and especially the problems of the first line supervisor as in a sense the man in the middle. And in particular, how the problems and the possibilities changed with the development of mining technology – and that's what my first paper was about: the shift from this pillar-and-bord working, where the coal was mainly hand hewn with with just picks, you'd have picked it out, to the first kind of mechanised mining, where you have "long-wall" mining, where you had a machine that went along the face and cut a slice of coal, and then it had to be hand-loaded into the tubs, so it was kind of half and half. And then finally you got the cutter/loader system, where the machine both cut and, by and large, loaded the coal. So all these technological changes created different managerial problems. (pp. 8-9)

3: From History to Sociology

I got into the early work on mining in part as a result of moving over from history – which I did my first degree in – to sociology, because I read history at University College, London, it was a wonderful training, a very very professional school. I mean, I think I got

a much better professional training as a historian there than I would have done at Oxford or Cambridge. And I taught history at Cambridge for a while later on. I specialised in economic and social history, and I was mainly interested in this whole, as it were, transition, first of all from so-called "feudalism", "manorial system", to more commercial agriculture, and then the later transition to industrialism. I got especially interested in the sociology of work.

That then led to the transition that I decided to make from history to doing graduate work in sociology - mainly through what I read in French literature where there was more or less a unified tradition of "sociologie du travail" and "histoire du travail". So that what I then became interested in, and what I wanted to do my thesis on, was the evolution of managerial systems in mining. Because one of the issues that emerged as you got larger industrial enterprises – and this really began in Britain in the 18th century, because mines were some of the largest industrial enterprises before the beginning of the factory system – how did you manage the workforce? (p. 8)

Your best known early article argues for the importance of history in social research, how far do you still hold this view?

Well, my views on the relationship between history and sociology have certainly changed. That early article, early 1960s, was a bit of a reaction against what, at the time, I saw as being a very ahistorical nature of a lot of American sociology of the day. I mean, on the one hand, Parsons' abstract system - social system - theory, and on the other hand the kind of survey research that was very much oriented towards attitudes. I did feel that both these approaches – the theoretical and the empirical – really paid very little regard to historical context. So that was behind that paper.

But I did write, actually I think early 1972, a postscript to that paper, which is in this book, edited by Martin Bulmer, *Sociological Research Methods*. He reprinted the original paper, but I wrote a postscript because, at around that time – early seventies – my views were changing, and, really, in reaction to what I called, in a later paper, "grand historical sociology", ... starting with [Shmuel] Eisenstadt's sociology of empires, and then very influential, Barrington-Moore's work. Then also, Theda Skocpol on revolutions, Perry

Anderson's work, and then after that, Michael Mann. I really felt that what this work showed was that these people did not understand, or did not want to understand, how history was actually written.

Coming from my original training as a historian, in a very professional History School at UCL, where we were always taught [methodology] - we had a kind of catechism, you know, one of the first questions, "What is the nature of historical fact?" And the answer was, "A historical fact is an inference from the relics". You only write history from what's left from the past, whether it's bones or pots, most commonly, of course, documents of one kind or another, and you always have to link it to that: and the idea that the inferences that you draw from the relics, are generally rather problematic and tenuous, need a great deal of care in interpretation, and always open to revision and so on. And then I found these people, ironically, since they were often represented as part of the reaction against positivism in sociology: taking what I'd been taught was an extremely positivist view of historiography, that the facts are there... I was really shocked when I read Barrington-Moore, about what seemed to be the very low quality of his understanding of, for example, the history of the English Civil War. He just seemed to take whatever interpretation of this, or the French Revolution, that suited his general argument, and neglect the rest... He just didn't know what had happened to the historiography of the French Revolution! So I did have a big reaction against that kind of grand historical sociology. I didn't think it was doing any favours to history or to sociology.

Then more recently, as I worked more and more in comparative sociology - in comparative studies of social mobility, for example - I've come to view something on these lines. I was very influenced by a book, it came out somewhere, I think, in the seventies, by Przeworski and Teune, on comparative sociology. And their programme was that you should try to replace the names of nations with the names of variables, and the idea was that it doesn't help very much if you say, to take a medical example - Japan has much lower rates of premature death from heart disease than America. That doesn't tell you very much. So you've to try and replace "Japan" and "America", with some relevant variable, like consumption of saturated fat, and then you're getting somewhere. That's

what really matters. You've to say why, what is it about America or Japan that is relevant to this?

So when we were doing our comparative mobility research, if we were trying to explain cross-national differences in the rates of mobility, we had to look for some variables that we could put the countries on, not just say, "Well, Germany is different", "England is different from the Netherlands", "Japan is different" - that's not very informative. So we had to look at things like, for example, things like degree of income inequality, differences in distribution of education. Well, let's put these variables in - and that's what I think sociologists should try to do. But then, at the same time, you have to recognise that this Przeworski-Teune programme has limits, and you come to a point where it really is the case that let's say, "Germany is just Germany. It's different. There's something about the German educational system that is specifically German", and the only way you could make that into a variable, would be to score Germany 1 and all the others 0! (LAUGHS) It's not very informative!

So in this way, I think, I see this as the borderline between sociology and history, and at some point, the Przeworski-Teune programme comes up against the buffers, and you have to say, "Yes, there were certain things in German history, and development of German culture, which just meant they ended up with an educational training system that was really very different from anywhere else". And that's really all you could say - just something very specific, unique to Germany. And again, you will look at a country like Hungary, and you find differences there, which you cannot treat in terms of variables, they just reflect the fact that after the First World War, Hungary was chopped down enormously in size, then it had a highly autocratic regime, then a Communist regime, but more recently moved back again to capitalism. These are just specific features of Hungarian society, and even under communism there was some very distinctive features of Hungarian society that made it a very different communist society from, say, Polish society. So in some ways, I see, now, history as a limiting factor for sociology: that sometimes you have to appeal to history, yeah, that the explanation is historical. But I still see a clear distinction between historical explanations and sociological explanations. (pp. 71-73)

4: Grammar School and Social Class

I started at grammar school in ’45, and by that time, the tripartite system was up and running. The thing was, did you pass the 11+? I went to Wath Dearne Grammar School. ... The Grammar School was a very interesting place, because it was, very largely a working-class and lower middle-class grammar school. Again later, when I read Jackson and Marsden [*Education and the Working Class*, 1962}, I thought, “Well, okay. That was their grammar school. Quite different from my grammar school”. And again, “Don’t generalise from Jackson and Marsden. Because they were concerned with working-class kids who went to a grammar school where the majority of children were from middle-class homes, and they were in a minority”. But that wasn’t at all the case in my grammar school.

There were four or five grammar schools built in South Yorkshire in the inter-war years - 1920s – part of a very enlightened educational programme for the West Riding of Yorkshire, inspired by a man whose biography should be written, a man called A.B. Clegg, who was Director of Education, West Riding - starting before the War, and right the way through in my time there in school. And there was Wath, Thorne, Goole, Maltby schools, and Mexborough was linked in to these five schools, but that had been established rather earlier, a little bit different. But in these areas, there wasn’t a developed middle class. They were largely mining industrial areas. In the catchment area of Wath School, there wasn’t a serious middle-class. You had a few mine managers, you’d got some doctors and parsons/ministers, but overwhelmingly it was a working-class although middle-class area. If I think of my school friends, their fathers were miners, mainly skilled miners, or craftsmen who worked down the mine – mine electricians, mine bricklayers – or they were sons of people who had local shops, groceries, radio and electrical shops and things like that. And because, insofar as there was a managerial and professional middle-class, then they quite often sent their children to private schools anyway. I mean, not Harrow, Eton, but just local private schools of no great distinction, just because they, I think, thought the grammar schools were really not suitable because they were predominantly drawing on kids from working-class and lower middle-class backgrounds.

I think the more I read about this, and I still do read quite a bit of history, I think that the 1930s marked, really, a peak in status anxiety, especially on the part of the lower white-collar groups. I saw that in my family, because what was really happening in the 1930s, okay, working-class living standards were depressed and held back because of the slump, but once the worst of that was over, for those workers who were in jobs in the 1930s, wages were actually increasing and there was quite a bit of economic growth. Certainly the miners if they had a job - and that's the important thing – they weren't doing too badly. And then, of course, in the War, this was intensified.

I can see it in my own family. There was some kind of status panic, almost, that their position was being threatened. And I think this was much more general. If you read social history of the thirties, you find this extraordinary preoccupation among lower middle-classes with maintaining status – I mean, exclusivity in clubs, great concern over dress, how you should dress to make sure you weren't taken at least for the rough working-class. My mother would never go out of the yard with a pinafore, she would just stop at the door. My father would never go out with braces showing, you always had to have a a waistcoat or a pullover. All these kinds of things where you had to make the distinction. My mother would always change in the middle of the afternoon. In the morning she would work very hard, cleaning, washing, cooking and keeping everything meticulous in the house, and then about three o'clock she would go and wash and change. And then in the evening, nothing grand, but she would be out of her working clothes.

In all these ways, it was to make distinctions. And it went all the way up. For my parents, it was splendid that I was going to grammar school. But one of my father's sisters married a small - well, not small, he had a men's outfitting shop, more middle middle-class, and, of course, their children had to go to private school, and so as you went, you've to make these distinctions!

Well, the first thing was, of course, that in going to the Grammar School, I think I was the only one from my primary school, in that year - no, there were two, two of us went to Grammar School. Of course, I found this a bit odd – leaving my other school friends behind, and in particular there was one girl, the same year as me in the primary school, who nearly always did better than me at school. She lived in the roughest part of the

village – a row of houses by a pond, which nearly always flooded. Her father never really worked, he was the local poacher, her mother would regularly get drunk and walk through the streets, singing, late at night. And she never'd any idea, she didn't even take the 11+, you know, she just had to work. No question. And interestingly enough, in later life she did qualify as a school teacher. She went back, and that was marvellous, and then died, very young, of cancer, unfortunately. But that was odd, you saw this idea that some of your friends and schoolmates were going to grammar school, the others were just going to the secondary modern school for one more year really.

But there was no kind of Bourdieusian culture shock in going to the Grammar School, it was just the same sort of children, by and large. The other big shock about it - well, not shock, that's too strong a word - the thing I didn't approve of was at school, the Grammar School, you had to play rugby, whereas, of course, in the village, it was all soccer, it was a soccer area, and I played a lot of soccer, and so I thought that was rather peculiar. It turned out I could play rugby quite well, and I played for the school teams and so on. But no, it wasn't very different at all, and the main problem, for me, in the Grammar School, was that because I lived so far away, and there was no public transport, I couldn't take part in any after school activities. So I was never as fully integrated into the School as I might have been. (pp. 10-13)

5: Discovering Statistics: Lancelot Hogden and David Glass

She was wonderful! Really terrific maths teacher! One day - we used to have these lessons in the library – just the one-on-one – and I was waiting for in the maths section of the library, and I saw, on the shelf, a book with this title, *Mathematics for the Million*. Yes, Lancelot Hogben. So I was looking through it, and she came in, and she said, "I suppose you've discovered that it's not for the million, because it does get pretty tricky". I said, "Yeah, well, I've just been looking at it". And she said, "Well, what we could do, we could work through parts of it". Okay. That was my introduction to statistics, and statistical thinking. I thought this was such a terrific book. So at the end of the year, I took the 'O' Level in maths and did quite well in it, but I can tell you now, or later, that had a very significant effect on my career, by a sheer fluke! ...

Well, what happened was, after I took my degree in history – I managed to get a First – and so I got a Coal Miners Social Welfare Scholarship to do my graduate work, so the mining background came in well. And Tom Bottomore gave me some very good advice at that time. I met him at a conference for historians and sociologists, and he told me there was a man at LSE, called John Smith, who was an industrial sociologist.... And he would be the person to supervise me, because he did know this French tradition. Bottomore had translated Georges Friedmann's book, [*Industrial* Society, 1955] which was, you know, like the text book for this. He knew that Smith knew this literature. So when I went to LSE to do a Ph.D. in Sociology, I was to be supervised by Smith, who was in Social Policy... So, as a formality, just to keep the books straight, as it were, I had to have another formal supervisor in Sociology. [David] Glass was professor and Head of Department, so he just took this on as a formality, but I was told that I should, as it were, pay a courtesy call on Glass.

I knew nothing about Glass, and so I went to see him, and he just asked me about my background and so on, and then what I was going to do and so on, and he said, "Do you have any mathematical background?" And I said, "Well, no. I mean, I can only do 'O' Levels, but in this year in the sixth form, I did try and work through some of a book by Lancelot Hogben, *Mathematics for the Million*". He looked at me, he said, "You've read Hogben, *Mathematics for the Million*?" He was Glass's supervisor! ... So, Glass, you know, "You ought to do what I'm doing", and so on, so this sheer fluke! And he told me what he'd been doing, this social mobility, and so I remember going off to the Economist Bookshop and buying Glass's book. So this was a sheer fluke, just a chain of random events. (pp. 16-17)

6: Norbert Elias and Ilya Neustadt

So I decided to go to Leicester, because I was very impressed by Neustadt – just as a character, strange. He was born in - well, geographically, Bessarabia, which was a disputed area, but at least he thought of himself as a Rumanian. He'd originally thought about being a doctor, or a professional violinist. He was a superb violinist. But then decided he would do law, and with the Rumanian and French language connection, he went to Liege, and did a doctorate – actually published – on international law. He became

somewhat interested in sociology, then in 1939, got one of the last boats out of Belgium, [came to England] and went to … to LSE and did a Ph.D. there. (p. 19)

What happened was, you see, when I went there – to Leicester – after being a sociologist officially, for only a year, I really didn't know much about the subject. My views on it were very inchoate, and over the three years there, in that first year with Elias, and then after with Elias and Neustadt, we spent an enormous amount of time talking, if you like, about foundational issues, and I learnt an enormous amount from them. Because Neustadt, as I've said, really came in this French tradition. He was steeped in Comte, he was a great admirer of Comte, always planned to write a great book on Comte – unfortunately it never happened. Elias went to Heidelberg just after Max Weber died, but he was part of the Marianne Weber circle. He was a student with Mannheim, and so he was steeped in this German tradition, so one could learn a lot. But as we talked over these three years, I realised that there were some very big differences between us, and I never could accept Elias's, if you like, "system of sociology". In fact, I wasn't sure that he had one. He was a brilliant, but I think idiosyncratic, one-off scholar.

But the whole emphasis in Leicester was teaching sociology in a developmental and comparative way, and with the comparative part I was entirely happy. I've done a lot of comparative work myself. I was never quite sure what they meant about "development", whether they regarded this as being purely a descriptive concept so that you could look back at the past and say, "This is how it developed", or whether it did have some more historicist, teleological element – they knew where it was going – and I never thought that Elias came out absolutely clearly one way or the other on this. I think he really did feel that there was some kind of inherent dynamic in the movement of human societies, and we also used to have big arguments about his developmental approach, especially this idea, I remember that he had this notion of increasing individuation, and wanted to allege that individuation was less in stateless societies. And I'd always been a great reader since I found them at primary school of Icelandiic/Nordic sagas, and these were about stateless societies, but anybody who's read those could not believe that the characters in them were not individuated...

Then the other was, I thought, their pretty naïve approach towards quantification. They never really, seemed to me, to grasp the role of it. It wasn't that they didn't understand the statistics – neither had any statistical training at all - but that wasn't the main problem. I don't think they ever saw how a lot of the things one wants to study in sociology, and say in sociology, have to be expressed, to some extent, quantitatively. Having discovered the Glass approach at LSE, really there were two people, in a way, at LSE, that stood between me and the Elias Neustadt tradition. One was Popper, because at LSE I went to Popper's lectures, and I thought they were superb – wonderful clarity and simplicity of thought, but very deep ideas, and I always thought that, in some ways, Elias was a covert historicist in the Popperian sense. And then Glass. And also I should say, inspired by Glass, I went to Claus Moser's lectures on quantitative methods for sociologists, and they were superb. Claus was wonderful, because he didn't make any big mathematical demands, he really taught statistics more from the point of view of the logic of what it was about, and he told me, some years after, that he was terrified when Allen, who was Professor of Statistics there, told him that he would have to give these lectures. Because Claus, in a way, never thought that he knew much about theoretical mathematical aspects of statistics. He was very much an applied man in descriptive statistical data analysis....

Another problem with Norbert [Elias] - although he probably wouldn't agree to this – I did find his whole approach too inductive. He had the idea - he's written this down in several places - that you have an idea, he paid enormous attention to empirical material, historical material, and then, if that doesn't quite fit the idea, you adjust it. It was an early version of what's become known as "grounded theory", where you constantly adapt your theoretical, or at any rate, your conceptual position, to new data. And as somebody influenced by Popper, I felt that was a bit of a cop-out. I mean, at some point I think you have to come forward with a clear testable proposition, and see whether it stands up against the empirical data. And, okay, you may want to refine it a bit, and modify it, but you've always to keep in mind that, at some point, you may have to say, "No. That's wrong!" And start again – not this endless adjustment and adaptation. And so that was a worry. ((pp. 21-23)

7: Towards Quantitative Sociology and Social Mobility

But anyway, on the question of quantitative versus qualitative, I think my position on that really only began to change during the time in Cambridge. I mean, the Affluent Worker project wasn't especially quantitative. It was designed as a critical case study, and okay, we took samples and we had some tables, but, I mean, apart from the odd significance test, there was no multivariate analysis in it at all. I did, though, start then - this was the first time I got sort of academically interested in social mobility as such. With Glass it was more a way of seeing how, as it were, quantitative thinking could fit into sociology, and it just happened that the subject was social mobility. ...

Then I became aware that I did need to improve my statistical knowledge, because by that time you had people like Otis Dudley Duncan in the States using regression approaches to social mobility, and then developing these into causal path analysis. So I began to be more aware, there, of how relatively advanced statistical techniques could have major sociological potential. I guess what further changed my view was, by the end of the sixties, one had – well, in Britain and elsewhere – this so-called "reaction against positivism", and then the attacks on quantitative methods, and I thought – and I still think – that was the big disaster in British sociology, and I really didn't have much sympathy, or very much patience, to be honest, with the various alternatives that were floated around, ranging from phenomenology and ethnomethodology at one extreme to weird forms of structuralist Marxism, Althusser, et.al – at the other. I thought that was going nowhere. (p. 25)

8: British and European Sociology

I was very much interested in this French *sociologie du travail* group, and when I moved to Leicester, Neustadt spoke fluent French, and he had French contacts, and I went over to France quite a bit in those years, to meet up with people there. I used to go to Raymond Aron's seminars at the Sorbonne. I spoke French fairly fluently, but inaccurately, and with a very bad accent! But I persevered, but then when I married my wife, that ruined my French because I knew I was always getting, like, ß- - (beta double minus), and when we went to France, as we did a lot, she would always say, "Oh, let me do the talking", because she could pass for French.... I'm afraid my spoken French really went down. I

still speak it from time to time if I have to, but I still read it, I have no problem reading it, but [my] spoken French is not too good.

Was Alain Touraine one of the group people who influenced you?

He was. He, of course, made this bridge between *sociologie du travail* and sociology. His first [work] - I think his thesis with Friedmann was on the evolution of work at the Renault factories, and that was a very important book. But then, because of what I think of as the unfortunate aspects of French intellectual culture, to get his big thesis, he had to write some large theoretical work which I don't think went anywhere at all. It was a great pity. (pp. 26-27)

[Looking back now] I feel pleased that I could do something to push sociology on in the way in which I think it should go. No, I just enjoyed it. It was a very exciting time. And what I – to be honest, what I feel - if it's a case of feeling proud - what I feel more proud about is the part that I've been able to play from a more, if you like, organisational standpoint in European sociology. I was one of the founder editors of the *European Sociological Review*, which we had to found because other people in other European countries were having the same difficulty as I felt here, that there weren't journals that would want our work, or where we would want it to appear. And that's now going very well indeed. It's challenging the *AJS* and the *ASR*. And then I was one of the people who helped found the European Consortium for Sociological Research, which is going strong still, and bringing together institutions in Europe with similar ideas of where sociology should be going, and what it should be like, and we've now, I think, over 40 institutions affiliated to the Consortium. Then more recently, I wasn't involved in an organising role, but I was an active participant in two EU networks of Centres of Social Excellence. (pp. 44-45)

Since the mid-seventies, I've had very little connection with British sociology. I was editor of *Sociology* when I first came here – '69-'72 – and I found it increasingly difficult to deal with the BSA Committee, because I followed Michael Banton, who was first editor, and we both put together a Board we thought comprised the people who were doing the most important work in British sociology at the time. There were some very

good people there. People at Liverpool still doing industrial sociology, Raymond Illsley in Scotland, doing very good medical sociology, and I think, if you look at the people who were on the Board at that time, they all did have very well-deserved and well-established reputations. But I was under constant pressure from the BSA Executive to change. We had to have so many Marxists, and so many phenomenologists, and so many women, and so many people from Polytechnics. I thought, "No, that is not the way to go". So relations became more and more strained, and I didn't want to do a second term as Editor, and I don't suppose I would have been allowed to do so anyway! (LAUGHS)

The same year, or around that same period, I remember going to one or two BSA Conferences, and one on race relations in particular, when nobody seemed to be reporting very much research on race relations. It was all going around sniffing each others' position, whether they were racist or not, and there was all this ideological argument. And that was my last BSA Conference. I stopped subscribing to BSA, and I've never been a member since then. It's sad, in a way, but I just didn't find what was happening in British sociology very appealing, and not intellectually interesting. So I was very fortunate that, you know, I had these European contacts. (pp. 46)

Of all your books, which is the one you'd most like to be remembered for?

I think the one that I would hope would have longest effect, would be the last, *On Sociology*, because, obviously, in the nature of the case, the ones based on research become dated. Other people will do not only more up to date, but better research on social mobility and stratification. But I hope that the *On Sociology* book will have some longer-term effects. Typically, it was scarcely reviewed in Britain: *BJS* did a review, *Sociological Review* didn't review it. *Sociology* didn't review it, they passed it on to *Work and Society*. But it's been very widely reviewed elsewhere, and now there are Italian and Spanish translations, and just last month, there's a Polish translation ...

I think what's happening in European sociology now, or, at least, the European sociology that's represented through the Consortium and these networks, is really very exciting, and in many ways I think there's more happening and of greater interest than in American sociology. So I'm very optimistic from that point of view, and that's where my work, I

think, gets most widely cited – people trying to put together some idea of a quantitative sociology which is, at the same time, trying to address major substantive problems, and that requires a theoretical input, where theory is not just for decoration or conceptual elaboration, but really for explanation. I mean, we come up with these - I think in many ways fascinating empirical regularities - and then the question is how to explain them. (pp 50-51)

Is there anything that's been a major disappointment, professionally?

Yes. I've not been able to do the same things that I've done in a European sociological context, in a British context. I mean, since the mid-seventies, I've just felt a complete outsider as far as British sociology is concerned, and I've not seen any way of doing that, because I think the prevailing conception of sociology in Britain since the mid-seventies, has been so different to what I would have in mind. So that it's been very difficult to do anything. If I look at a journal like *Sociology*, or *Sociological Review*, it's as if it's a different subject, a different discipline to the one that I work in. I can't see any common ground at all. Well, *BJS* is a bit more mixed. But that's been I think the major disappointment. And some time towards the end of the seventies, when I had this very good group of graduate students, or people who were just starting their academic careers, we talked about this, and I said, "Do you think there would be any point in getting more involved in the BSA and trying to change it?" And we talked about this, and their view, in the end, was "Well, no". They'd rather just get on with doing their own work more in a European context, and not bother with British sociology. (pp. 63-4)

9: Durkheim

I've never been a Durkheim admirer. I've always felt that he did more damage to sociology (LAUGHS) than good! I think he - to put it very crudely - had a basic holistic conception of society, exaggerated – in my view – to an impossible degree, and over-emphasised, seriously, the extent to which individuals, their actions and relationships, were not just conditioned, but really very clearly moulded by socio-cultural factors. And too much mysticism about these *courants suicidogènes* that somewhere exist up here [POINTS UPWARDS]. I found it too mystical. And then, although he's always

presented as the great pioneer of quantitative sociological analysis in *Suicide*, I think that's really a myth, because his whole basic method is logical analysis, and Durkheim really had no idea of correlation. If you look at his arguments in *Suicide*, they all suppose that something is correlated, or associated, with something else – either totally or not at all. The correlation coefficient is either 1 or 0, and there's nothing in between. And so it was, in many ways, a profoundly non-statistical way of using quantitative evidence. And, you know, it has been shown to be defective. I also felt he was far too rhetorical. Some of his arguments are much more based on rhetoric than really hard logic in every sense.... So although there's some aspects of French social thought that obviously attracted me from the start, Durkheim didn't figure. (p. 32)

10: Methodological Individualism

To simplify it, it's more the individualistic paradigm as opposed to the holistic paradigm, that you really begin with - or end might be a better way. But all explanations of social phenomena have, in the end, to be given in terms of individual action and interaction. It's Popperian methodological individualism.... I really do think that in social life, causal efficacy – if you want to put it that way – ultimately resides in individual action. Of course, this action is always conditioned by social phenomena which have their own *sui generis* existence.... Obviously social phenomena have their own reality, but if you want to explain them, then in the end it has to come down to to individual action. That's the methodological individualism. (pp. 33-34)

11: The Affluent Worker

I don't think there's anything remarkably new in the Affluent Worker studies. We developed a new approach in industrial sociology. I very much changed tack from my earlier interest in what you might call "technological implications". We did pick the three firms with that approach in mind, and especially under the influence of this work by an American sociologist, Robert Blauner, but we realised, as the results came in, that effects of technology were really very limited, and we developed this idea of "orientations to work". Again, it fitted in with my general view that what's important are individuals'

actions, the goals that they have, and interactions with others that this leads them into. I always remember, coming from a mining background, what really struck me, they had this phrase - we asked them, in the interviews, how often men we interviewed saw people they worked with outside of work. Scarcely ever. And the phrase that came out, "mates aren't friends". Now, in a mining context, a mining community, that would have made no sense at all. Your mates were your friends... But, of course, then you think about it, and yes, it makes sense, because the people you were working with, you had a very close relationship with them, because your safety as well as your earnings, depended absolutely on them....

I was a bit surprised, to be honest, about the way *The Affluent Worker* became sort of enshrined in British sociology. I mean, only a few years ago, Cambridge reprinted it, and in some ways, to be honest, I think it's a pity, I don't think undergraduates in British sociology departments should be reading *The Affluent Worker* now. I think it should have been consigned to history 20/30 years ago. (pp. 36-37)

12: The Nuffield Social Mobility Study
Causal Path Analysis and Log Linear Modelling

I think we were able, for the first time, in a national survey, to really get to grips with some fundamental, conceptual issues in studying mobility, and to translate these into appropriate statistical techniques. What we planned to do originally – and this was really Chelly Halsey and Jean Floud's idea – was to do a study that would, on the one hand, replicate Glass, and so bring Glass up to date, and allow for comparisons over time with Glass, and secondly, would replicate Blau and Duncan with their more advanced regression methods, and allow a comparison between Britain and the United States. What we discovered, in the early years of the project - and I think I was quite heavily involved in this – that neither of these two things was, in fact, possible. We couldn't replicate Glass because the basic coding in Glass, of occupations, was to the Hall-Jones Scale, which was defective in many ways, and there was no clear guidance, no clear manual for doing this coding. The two documents that were available were contradictory in regard to many occupations. And we couldn't get the original schedules to re-code the data.

John Ridge and Kenneth MacDonald spent many weeks trying to track these down. We thought we'd traced them to a warehouse in Neasden, of all places! We got a shelf reference to this warehouse, and when they got there, the shelf was empty. Probably they'd been destroyed.... So all that was left from the Glass study were the punched cards, but the coding was already in there.

Then with the Blau and Duncan approach, this involved in having continuous scales of occupations. They used the Duncan SEI Index - and also of education – they used years of education. Well, years of education didn't make all that much sense in Britain, with the kind of educational system that we had. But more to the point, the majority of people in the sample that we took in 1972 had minimal education. They left school at the end of compulsory education. So to try and standardise a distribution of that kind, where you got this great block with the same value, made no sense.

I also became more and more doubtful about the methodology of causal path analysis, and that, in a way, came from my background with Glass, because there are really two traditions, certainly in British statistics: one really that wants to translate everything into continuous variables, going back to Karl Pearson, and the other that Yule pioneered, of giving a very clear place for analysis of categorical data, and Glass was very much in that tradition. So Glass was very sceptical about path analysis on statistical grounds, and so was I. Mainly because the results you would get are based on the assumption that the same regression rules apply across the whole population, and nobody believes that's true. There are different degrees of association between social origins and eventual destinations, depending on what your social origins were. You can aim to capture it all in one number, but I think that's very misleading....

Let me just give one very clear example of that. Take people who grow up in families of small entrepreneurs - small shopkeepers, small builders, craftsmen. We know that the sons have a very high propensity to follow on. They inherit the business, and take it over. So there's a much stronger propensity for immobility, given those origins, than if your father, say, was a clerk, or a wage worker. It's not uniform, you can't capture it in one single set of regression rules. So we moved towards this categorical approach, and I

developed this class schema. This meant we needed an appropriate method of statistical analysis that would handle categorical data. Glass had used categorical data, but then the big problem with his work was that he never – well, it really wasn't available in those days – [had the] appropriate statistical technique to handle data of this kind... So we struggled with this for a while, and then it was actually at an ISA meeting in Poland, a place near Warsaw, that I saw the way ahead. I'd been working with disparity ratios, not a very good statistical measure, and then Bob Hauser gave a paper there on "log linear modelling" – which I knew nothing about – and began by saying the basic element of all log linear models is an odds ratio. I realised, as he put the algebra on the board, that an odds ratio was simply the product of two complementary disparity ratios that I'd been working with. And then as he went on, it became clear to me that this was the technique that we needed. Because this could solve the old problem of how you dealt with what used to be called "structural" and "exchange mobility". ... This led, then, to the distinction that I made – I think I did pioneer this – between absolute and relative mobility rates, which, I think, is quite fundamental to understanding social mobility. And I think what is important about this is that it shows how conceptual development and development in quantitative analysis really have to go together. This is why I get a bit annoyed when people just talk about number crunching, because they don't see that analysing the numbers, and grappling with the quantitative problems, can give you new conceptual insights about how you should think about the sociological problem that you've got. So that was really, I think, the main achievement of British mobility work. (pp. 37-39)

13: Causal Path Analysis and Log Linear Modelling

Causal path analysis is a form of correlation and regression analysis, and to use it, you really need to work with continuous variables. So if you were wanting to study social mobility this way, you might, for example, take a scale of occupational prestige or status, and consider individuals on positions on this scale – their destination positions, and then their fathers', or their parental position on this scale - that would be the origins. And then you would measure social mobility, or immobility, simply by the correlation between the score of the father, on the occupational status scale, and the score of the child on the occupational status scale. That would probably work out at something like 0.3-0.4. Okay. So then you might want to ask for - well, what about variables that mediate

between origin and destination, in terms of occupational status? And an obvious candidate here would be education. So you want to measure that in a continuous way, say years of completed education. Then, what causal path analysis would allow you to do, would be to decompose this overall correlation of, let's say about 0.3 or 0.4, into two parts – one part that went through education, from origin to education, and then from education to destination; and the other part that didn't go through education, if you like – the direct effect. And then, of course, you could elaborate on this. You could bring in a fourth and fifth variable. You might want to bring in IQ as measured in early life. You might want to bring in occupational status of the first occupation that the individuals had on entering the labour market. And path analysis will then allow you still finer decomposition of this overall association through all the paths that you might draw between these variables. So from that point of view, it can be quite revealing.

However, it's got at least two big problems. One is it's a form of standardised regression, so really, you can't separate out the effects of the marginal distributions of all these variables from the effects of their net correlation. You can't take account, for example, of the fact that between the parents' generation and the child's generation, the shape of the occupational structure may have changed, or the distribution of education may have changed, and that becomes especially problematic when you may want to be comparing samples over long periods of time, or across countries. Second problem is that it's totally a linear system, and you have to assume that the results you come up with, just apply equally across the whole of the population that you're looking at. For example, you've got to assume that the role of education in social mobility is the same wherever you start off and wherever you end up, and, in fact, we know that's not true. For example, if you're the son of a small proprietor, a lot of sons of small proprietors end up simply inheriting the family business, and education is of pretty negligible importance. On the other hand, if you're the son of a manual wage worker, and you end up as a salaried professional, you can be pretty sure education was crucial. So it assumes, path analysis, that the same regression rules apply across the board, and we know that's not true.

Okay, log-linear modelling - again, thinking of it in terms of mobility analysis - here you're basically working with categorical variables, and you don't even have to assume that they're ordered, they're just different. So you could think, in this case, say, of social

mobility, in terms of some kind of class schema. You might think of the classes as being ordered but for the purposes of analysis, that doesn't matter. So you have a mobility table which simply classifies individuals by their own class position as against their parents' class position. And what log-linear modelling then will enable you to do, is to look at the association between origins and destinations defined in this way, using what we call "odds ratios", and in this case you can very clearly separate out the effects of changes in the marginal distributions from any changes in the underlying association, net of the marginal distributions. And moreover, you can do this almost on a cell by cell basis, so you don't have to assume that the same patterns of association operate across the board. It's a much more disaggregated kind of analysis. So you can say, "Yes, small proprietors, self-employed workers, have a much higher propensity for immobility than do, say, clerical workers - things of this kind. So it's very valuable when you want to look at changes in mobility over time, or across societies, because you can make then this crucial distinction between absolute mobility rates, which reflect the effects of changes in the marginal distributions, from relative mobility rates which just focus on the net associations. However, then there is a downside, and that is that it's much more difficult, taking this approach, to bring in intervening, mediating variables like education, and to distinguish the indirect and direct effects. Now, this is one of the big statistical issues at the moment – how can you do the equivalent of causal path analysis in this context of discrete variables and non-linear models? (pp. 79-81)

14: Women and Social Mobility

[For the Nuffield Social Mobility Study] we applied to what was then SSRC... and we had a site visit from people from SSRC.... I think our limit was about £80,000, and we discussed, with them, what size of sample we should have. A point that became very debated later - and made me very angry - we discussed explicitly with them: whether we should limit to men, or include how many women, pointing out that if we took in women, then given the budgetary constraints they imposed upon us, we wouldn't be able to do the same degree of cross birth-cohort analysis. It had to go one way or the other. We did apply, and we discovered this only afterwards: we were turned down by the Sociology Committee, but we were supported by the Statistics Committee. Andrew Shonfield then

had a difficult decision to make – he was Chief Executive or Chairman or whatever – and he decided, and he told us afterwards, perhaps *ultra vires*, that the grant would go through.

That was my first experience of how real, in British sociology, the reaction against positivism was, and the hostility to quantitative research. Because such information as we were given as to why the Sociology Committee turned it down, seemed to amount to little more than that – that they didn't like quantitative research, and they felt too much money was going to quantitative research. Another thing that irritated me greatly was that when all the to do started afterwards, about why we'd not included women, one of the feminist cheerleaders on this was Margaret Stacey, who'd been a member of the site visiting party here, and had never raised that issue or said anything about it when she came here. So I wasn't too impressed by her performance, in that respect. (pp 41-42)

Have you included women in your subsequent social mobility studies? And has that affected conclusions from earlier studies?

Well, we did include women, at a later stage – and this is in the second edition of my book on *Social Mobility and Class Structure in Modern Britain*. By that time we could take more data from the British General Election Studies, to deal with women's mobility. And the short answer is that so far as inter-generational mobility is concerned, the patterns were essentially the same as for men, so none of the major conclusions from the first edition had to be changed. I mean, women, like men, across the cohorts we studied, had increasing chances of upward mobility that was almost entirely due to the marginal effects, the changing shape of the class structure. There's more room at the top, so, like men, they moved up. They didn't enter the higher level professional and managerial positions to the same extent, but still the clear pattern was for upward mobility, thinking in absolute terms. When you came to look at the relative rates then for women, just as for men, these were essentially stable across the cohorts, and there was no very great difference in the degree of fluidity between men and women. If anything, women possibly showed greater fluidity, but that was very doubtful - really not much difference. So from the point of view of intergenerational mobility, no, the gender differences were very slight when you looked at the trends.

In fact, now, in our current project, which is based on the British cohort studies, of course we can look at men and women, and now with some interest, it seems. We've a paper under review which is a bit more interesting in terms of gender differences. What we're finding now is that among women fluidity has increased – not among men – and the interesting question is why that should be so? There are two competing [answers] that we can't decide between at the moment, but we will. One is that education-based meritocracy is more developed among women than among men. Women have been, as we know, have been doing better than men educationally, and it does seem that women's educational attainment is somewhat less closely linked to their social origins than men. It may be that something is happening - that education counts for more for women in where they end up, than for men. So that's one possible interpretation, that women's mobility is being more governed by a kind of education-based meritocracy.

But there's another slightly less positive interpretation that what we're really seeing here is a kind of increase in "perverse" fluidity, and this comes about from the fact that more women than previously are not leaving the labour market in the period of active motherhood, but are staying in, but on a part-time basis, and often accepting some kind of job downgrading. So that perhaps women from more advantaged backgrounds, who, themselves, started off their working lives in managerial and professional positions - more of these women now are staying in the labour market, but being downwardly mobile in course of their own lives, and that then shows up in greater inter-generational fluidity. So both of these things could be true to some extent, but that's what we're working on at the moment. (pp. 82-3)

15: Computing in the 1970s

When Clive Payne and I started working with ECTA here, fitting very very simple log-linear models, we got a message from the Oxford Computing Service - you see, what happened was, we would send our models to the Oxford computer, it couldn't handle them. So it sent them then to London, and often London couldn't handle them. So the biggest computer was Manchester, and it went to Manchester, and it took us two or three days to get a result back. And, of course, it cost the University every time they passed it

on, and Manchester charged a lot, so we got this message from the Head of Computing Services saying did we realise that our computing costs were second highest in the University, exceeded only by those of Dorothy Hodgkin in the crystallography laboratory, who had just won the Nobel Prize! (LAUGHS) So no, we didn't recognise that, but what could we do? (p 41)

16: Sir David Cox

Fortunately, just at that time, David Cox had become Warden here, and even then, and certainly now, I would regard him as the greatest statistician in the world, and a remarkable man. So I didn't know him very well then, he'd only been Warden for a few months, so we said could we show him this model? And we went along with a little worked example, and he looked at it, and he said, "Yes. I like that. You can do that". He said, "The pure mathematicians won't like it, because you're multiplying logs, and mathematicians don't like multiplying logs, it's inelegant". But he says, "Never mind. I think it works". I didn't know him well then, and we looked at the worked example, and I remember him saying to me, "I'm not quite sure about the degrees of freedom here, whether you've really got four degrees of freedom", or whatever it was, and I rather brashly said, "Well, we must have more than three", and he looked at me with – now I recognise as his teasing look – and said, "Oh, so you're assuming that degrees of freedom are integers, are you?" "Yes!" (LAUGHS) I'd always assumed that! And he was making quite a subtle point about how we'd estimated the maximum likelihood ratio. But it was just a tease! (p. 43)

17: On Bourdieu

I think the effects of Bourdieu have just been overwhelmingly negative. And it's always the problem when you do some research and say, "This doesn't seem consistent with Bourdieu's position", "Oh, Bourdieu didn't say that, he said something else", and it's always something else. It's like trying to nail jelly to the wall! So I end up saying, "Well, please give me a statement of one of Bourdieu's theories and then tell me what I would

have to show, empirically, to make you believe that this theory was wrong". You can never get a clear answer. So, if a theory can't be tested in this way, can't be shown to be wrong, I don't see how it can contain any information. It has to be saying that something can't be the case, so it's testable. And if you can't test it, then what is it actually saying? And this is the problem that I always have with a lot of this so-called "social theory". Is it trying to offer testable explanations? If so, it's not clear what they are. Is it just playing around with concepts? Well, okay, it may be useful or not – it depends how illuminating the concepts turn out to be. (p. 54)

18: Longitudinal Cohort Studies and Intergenerational Transmission

Tak Wing Chan is now working on the three generation effect. The problem is, he's using the birth cohort studies [the 1946 and 1958 longitudinal cohort studies], which are I suppose really the only good data source on this, and the problem is that the cohort studies lack data on what I think is the most crucial - probably the most crucial - grandparental influence, and that is wealth – the handing down of money to fund children's private education, or help the parents to buy houses near good State schools, pay for private tuition. So far, he's found some three-generation effects, but they're not very big. In fact, there's a body of research that suggests they don't exist. He's been very critical of that and said they do exist, but so far he's only been able to show rather weak effects. They're significant, they're there, but the difficulty is, I think the crucial bit of data is missing, and that's wealth and the inter-generational transmission of wealth. The other thing that I thought you were going to say - that in many ways is another problem that we can, in principle, tackle on the basis of the cohort studies, but it's going to get very complicated – now is the number of kids with step-parents …

Because you don't know which household they're growing up in?

Exactly. So this is something that is on the agenda, but we have to look, see what data we've got on that. We will be able to follow through the parents who were in the original cohort, but if, say, the wife was in the original cohort, we will know, then, about her second or third husband, but the husband who wasn't in the cohort, we won't know

anything about his next wife if he found one. But what Bess Bukodi has done, and is really an extraordinary achievement, for the ’46 cohort as well as the ’58 and ’70 cohort, she has really got all the basic data of family history, employment history, occupational and class history, so for every cohort member we know where they were through their lives, month by month.

What a data set! The original data still survives?

Oh yes, it’s all there. It’s all coded up. No, it is all coded up. (pp. 56-57)

19: Imputing Missing Data

There are some problems with the ’46 [longitudinal cohort] data. And especially in periods where they’re harking back quite a long way. Not so much because there were gaps in the sweeps, but some people went missing and then they came back in and so on. In principle, all the data are there, for people who stayed in the cohorts.

What we’re also doing to try and check how serious this is in our big research project, which is on the role of education in social mobility, we’re, right now, doing a massive multiple imputation exercise. This is a bit of statistical black magic, where you impute missing data from the data, what you know, the data you have.

It sounds dangerous.

Not as much as it might seem at first sight. What you can say is that it’s less dangerous than proceeding on the basis of just the data you have. Because unless you can assume that the missing data is missing at random, which we know, for sure, it’s not, then there are two arguments. One, you can just work with the complete cases, only the complete cases, knowing that the missing cases will not be missing at random, or you can try and impute missing data. You don’t do it once, it’s called “multiple imputation”. You create maybe five or six different imputed data sets in different ways, and then you take an average value. So far there are no big differences in the results. You reduce the standard errors in the imputed data.

But we'll see. Obviously there are dangers in it, but you try and minimise these through the technique. Yes, it is a way of doing the best you can with what you've got, and it's probably better than ignoring missing data – or, at least, it's a check. If you use only the complete cases, then you do this multiple imputation, and you don't get very different results, then that's reassuring. (pp. 57-58)

20: Mixed Methods

Well, I should say, at the start, that I'm always very sceptical when people talk about "mixed methods" as if it's something, as it were, good in itself, without explaining why mixed methods might be thought to give an advantage. Although I primarily work in quantitative sociology because, I suppose, my overall conception of sociology is as a kind of population science, I mean, what we're really interested in is aggregate level regularities among human populations. I'm inclined to work quantitatively because that's the way I think you have to deal with population aggregates. But I do think that there is a role for qualitative work in sociology, in at least one particular respect, and that is where you've established, empirically, some population regularity which, for me, is the basic kind of explananda for sociology of established patterns of social mobility or patterns of formation and dissolution of partnerships, or whatever: we've done that statistically, then you want to be able to explain why these regularities are as they are, or if they change, why they change, and you can't do that through statistics. You've got to come up with some kind of social process or mechanism, at a level of social action and interaction that explains why, statistically, you can see these regularities, and once you come up with some theory - I mean, as in the genuine meaning of theory, I mean some explanatory model, something that tells you why something is as it is. Your next step, then, is to test that theory.

Here, I think there is a role for qualitative work, because there are basically two ways, I think, to test theoretical explanations of social regularities - explanations that are given in terms of social processes at the level of action. One is the kind of indirect test. You can say, "Well, if this mechanism that you propose is actually going on, then we ought to be

able to see this, this, and this - other indications". And you may then want to do more statistical analyses to see if you find that.

But the other way is more direct. We can say, "Well, if this process is really going on in families, or in schools, or wherever - all causation, in one sense, is local causation - we ought to be able to get in there and see it actually happening". And this is where, I believe, there still is a role for serious ethnography, but it has to be serious ethnography, and I think that we lost that in sociology – this kind of thing I call '*Blitzkrieg* ethnography", where, you know, somebody just hangs around for a few days, and does nothing very much. We've got to go back to the, if you like, the Malinowskian conception of ethnography, where people really did spend a long time in the field. (pp. 84-5)

21: Retirement and leisure

Do you think your life has changed much since you retired?

No, not very much at all, to be honest! ... : (LAUGHS) I haven't retired!... Yes, I retired in 2000 from my official Fellowship, but shortly after that, I was taken on again in the Department of Sociology, in connection with this research project that I did with Tak Wing Chan on "cultural consumption". ... So I'm still in gainful employment, and I don't think I shall retire....

We were very lucky. We had two children, and compared with, you know, a lot of our contemporaries, I have to say they were remarkably trouble-free children.... So family life, from that point of view, has been remarkably smooth. The only thing is, of course, that half of our family lives in Germany....

On the hobbies side, one thing that helped a bit with this, one of my hobbies has always been bird watching, and Robert Erikson is a great bird watcher. So wherever we are in the world we usually take off … And then I played soccer. All the time I was in Leicester I played soccer for a local works team in the local Leicester League, and after having been there a few months, I had a terrific collision with the opposing goal-keeper, and broke my nose – that was on the Saturday, and Monday morning I remember having to lecture with

two magnificent black eyes! And all the kids shouting, "What does the other fella look like, then!" (LAUGHS) And I kept playing tennis. I played regularly for King's when I was in Cambridge, and as [for tournament] tennis from time to time I played a bit.

I always played a lot of chess. Well, of course, when chess computers came in, I moved over to computer chess. I still play a bit of computer chess. And my other great thing is cryptic crosswords. I usually - when I've finished at the end of the day - I usually have about an hour doing the *Guardian* crossword, and then at the weekend, *The Observer*, the Azed crossword.

So that's the main. And we have this flat in the Barbican, so we go to a lot of concerts in the Barbican. I've always read a lot of poetry, not so much novels, but I still read a fair bit of poetry. It was wonderful, I don't know whether you heard it on radio just a few weeks ago - Tony Harrison reading V. That speaks a lot to my background, of course, that poem. I'm a terrific Harrison admirer. (pp. 54, 58-60, 62)